SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #18 · BELONGING AND BEING AN OUTSIDER

“If I leave my culture behind, I'm betraying my people.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Those who move for education, work, marriage, or faith can feel torn. Family may say, “You think you’re better than us,” or hint that adopting new ways is disloyal. We can feel guilt about changing language, food, customs, or beliefs, as if growth were abandonment.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture honors peoples and cultures: “From one man He made every nation of men,” and John sees “a multitude too large to count, from every nation and tribe and people and tongue” before the throne. Ruth left her homeland and told Naomi, “Your people will be my people, and your God will be my God,” and was honored. Paul writes that in Christ “there is no Greek or Jew… but Christ is all and is in all.” We can honor our heritage, keep what is good, and still follow Christ where His way differs from our culture’s. Changing does not mean betraying, and loving where we come from does not mean staying exactly the same.

> *“After this I looked and saw a multitude too large to count, from every nation and tribe and people and tongue, standing before the throne and before the Lamb. They were wearing white robes and holding palm branches in their hands”* (Revelation 7:9).

Also see

> “From one man He made every nation of men, that they should inhabit the whole earth; and He determined their appointed times and the boundaries of their lands” (Acts 17:26).

> “But Ruth replied: ‘Do not urge me to leave you or to turn from following you. For wherever you go, I will go, and wherever you live, I will live; your people will be my people, and your God will be my God.’” (Ruth 1:16).

> “Here there is no Greek or Jew, circumcised or uncircumcised, barbarian, Scythian, slave, or free, but Christ is all and is in all” (Colossians 3:11).

> “Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind. Then you will be able to test and approve what is the good, pleasing, and perfect will of God” (Romans 12:2).

Common self-statements

- If I change, I am abandoning them.
- They will think I am better than them.
- I owe them my loyalty in everything.
- Growing up means leaving them behind.
- I am a traitor if I adopt other ways.
- I cannot belong to two worlds.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I must keep everything or lose everything.
- Mind reading: Assuming my people think I am a traitor.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling guilty and concluding that I did something wrong.
- Should statements: Insisting that I must never change.

Challenging questions

- What parts of my culture do I treasure and want to keep?
- What parts of my culture conflict with my faith or conscience?
- What has changed, and was it a betrayal or growth?
- How can I express honor to my people in a new setting?
- What does Scripture say about every nation worshiping together?
- Who could I talk with who has navigated two cultures?

Truth summary

> I can honor my culture and my people while following Christ and growing. Not every change is betrayal. I can keep what is good, set aside what conflicts with God's way, and be a bridge.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Obedience
- Worldly
- Parenting
- Love, For Others
- Will of God

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Communication

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

If We Are the Body — Casting Crowns
The church is called to welcome and care for people rather than exclude or shame them.

Hello My Name Is — Matthew West
God's redeemed-child identity challenges labels of regret and defeat.

How Great Thou Art — Jordan Smith
This classic hymn connects God's greatness, Christ's sacrifice, and future hope.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "If I leave my culture behind, I'm betraying my people"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"If I leave my culture behind, I'm betraying my people." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What do I treasure?
- ☐ What conflicts with my faith?
- ☐ How have I grown?
- ☐ How can I honor my people?
- ☐ Who understands?
- ☐ What do I need to say?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God made every nation.
- ☐ Every nation will worship together.
- ☐ Ruth was honored for following God.
- ☐ Growth is not betrayal.
- ☐ I can honor my roots and grow.
- ☐ I can be a bridge.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Revelation 7:9
  "After this I looked and saw a multitude too large to count, from every nation and tribe and people and tongue, standing before the throne and before the Lamb. They were wearing white robes and holding palm branches in their hands."
- ☐ Ruth 1:16
  "But Ruth replied: 'Do not urge me to leave you or to turn from following you. For wherever you go, I will go, and wherever you live, I will live; your people will be my people, and your God will be my God.'"
- ☐ Acts 17:26
  "From one man He made every nation of men, that they should inhabit the whole earth; and He determined their appointed times and the boundaries of their lands."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Roots and growth: Each week, note one way you honored your culture and one way you grew.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Revelation 7:9 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Every nation will worship together, so honoring my roots and following Christ fit together.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Will of God" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ List what you treasure. Write the parts of your culture you want to keep.
- ☐ List what conflicts. Write what you cannot keep and why.
- ☐ Honor your people. Call, visit, or share food or stories.
- ☐ Find a bridge person. Talk to someone who lives between two cultures.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "If I leave my culture behind, I'm betraying my people": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Roots and growth
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If I leave my culture behind, I'm betraying my people.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, You made every people. Help me honor where I come from and follow You wherever You lead. Give me grace with those who worry I am leaving them. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.